CHAPTER 1
INTRODUCTION

AI Anxiety and Career Uncertainty Among Young Professionals in Bangladesh: Implications for Human Resource Management

Artificial intelligence (AI) raises a practical question for employees at the beginning of their careers: how can they build a sustainable professional future when the tasks and skills associated with their work may change? These concerns include learning new tools, the value of qualifications, promotion, and alternative employment. Human resource management (HRM) therefore needs to understand employee perceptions alongside the technical decisions involved in introducing AI.

International evidence presents both opportunities and risks. Gmyrek et al. (2025) estimate that one in four workers worldwide is employed in an occupation with some exposure to generative AI, while emphasising that exposure does not mean inevitable job loss. In a customer-support setting, Brynjolfsson et al. (2025) show that AI assistance can improve productivity, with gains differing across workers. Such findings challenge an exclusively displacement-based account. Nevertheless, potential benefits at organisational level do not establish that employees feel secure about their own futures.

This thesis examines the relationship between AI anxiety and career uncertainty among young professionals in Bangladesh and considers its implications for HRM. AI anxiety is treated as a technology-related psychological response, whereas career uncertainty concerns the perceived predictability and security of future career development. The proposed study focuses on employed professionals. It asks whether anxiety is associated with career uncertainty and how workplace learning opportunities and organisational support relate to these experiences.

BACKGROUND AND CONTEXT

AI systems can assist with writing, analysis, and organisational decisions. Their relevance extends beyond repetitive physical activities. However, tool availability does not establish organisational adoption, and adoption does not imply that entire jobs can be automated. Gmyrek et al. (2025) distinguish occupational exposure from realised employment outcomes and identify job transformation as the more likely overall outcome of generative AI. This distinction is important when interpreting public discussions about future employment.

Workers may respond to these developments differently. Training and supported practice may encourage a professional to view AI as useful assistance. Another may associate it with unrealistic performance expectations or declining occupational advantage. In an early employee study, Brougham and Haar (2018) examined awareness of smart technology, AI, robotics, and algorithms among 120 employees. Greater awareness of possible replacement was associated with lower organisational commitment and career satisfaction and higher turnover intentions and other adverse outcomes. These associations establish the relevance of employee perceptions, although the small, context-specific study cannot determine the experiences of Bangladeshi professionals.

AI anxiety also requires a more precise definition than a general dislike of technology. Wang and Wang (2022) developed an Artificial Intelligence Anxiety Scale covering learning, job replacement, sociotechnical blindness, and AI configuration. The scale distinguishes learning concerns from employment concerns and wider technological fears. Local adaptation remains necessary: some items may be less relevant to current applications, and translation may alter meaning or structure.

Career uncertainty is similarly broader than fear of losing a current job. Shoss (2017) conceptualises job insecurity around threatened continuity and stability of employment. Spurk et al. (2022) extend the discussion to multiple aspects of future

careers, including opportunities, employment conditions, and the fit between individual resources and work demands. For this thesis, career uncertainty refers to perceived difficulty anticipating a viable professional future, operationalised through clearly specified career-insecurity dimensions. It will not be equated with unemployment, career indecision, or a clinically diagnosed anxiety disorder. A person may remain employed while worrying that their skills will become less valuable or that their progression will stall.

Bangladesh provides an important setting for this inquiry because technological change intersects with existing employment constraints. Kapoor's (2026) analysis of recent Labour Force Surveys identifies persistent underemployment and informality, declining paid employment, and a weak connection between economic growth and employment expansion. These challenges are especially consequential for young people and women. The report provides labour-market context rather than evidence that AI caused these conditions. A credible study must therefore distinguish concerns associated with technology from insecurity arising through contracts, limited opportunities, organisational restructuring, and wider economic conditions.

Local evidence is emerging. Islam et al. (2026) published survey data from 3,156 students at five Bangladeshi universities concerning AI knowledge, use, perceived occupational threat, and career anxiety. The dataset demonstrates that AI-related career concerns can be studied locally, but its student population cannot represent employees already experiencing organisational policies and career progression. Biswas et al. (2026) investigate AI anxiety among university librarians in Bangladesh using a cross-sectional design. Their work adds occupational evidence, while leaving open questions about younger employees across different professional sectors. These studies support a more specific research gap than an assertion that Bangladesh has received no attention.

Conservation of resources theory provides the theoretical starting point. Hobfoll (1989) connects stress with threatened or actual loss of valued resources. Skills, income continuity, and opportunities may be perceived as resources at risk during technological change. This is a proposed explanation to investigate. Organisational support offers a complementary perspective: employees form beliefs about whether their organisation values their contribution and well-being (Eisenberger et al., 1986).

PROBLEM STATEMENT

The practical problem is that organisations may introduce AI without sufficiently understanding how younger employees interpret its implications for their careers. An implementation can improve an operational process while leaving workers uncertain about future responsibilities, promotion requirements, or access to training. Conversely, an organisation may misinterpret reasonable requests for information as resistance to change. Tambe et al. (2019) identify adverse employee reactions, fairness, accountability, and the complexity of employment decisions as central challenges in applying AI within HRM. These concerns justify examining the employment relationship rather than treating AI adoption solely as a technical project.

The research problem is more specific: the reviewed evidence does not establish how AI anxiety relates to broader career uncertainty among young, employed professionals across selected sectors in Bangladesh. International findings help identify relevant concepts, but their transfer depends on employment arrangements and organisational resources. The available Bangladesh studies address university students or a particular profession (Biswas et al., 2026; Islam et al., 2026). They do not, by themselves, establish the relationship proposed here for a cross-sector early-career employee population. This is a population-and-relationship gap within the literature located for this chapter, not a claim that the present thesis would be the first study of its kind.

A further problem concerns measurement. If an AI-anxiety questionnaire asks whether technology threatens employment, and a career-uncertainty questionnaire repeats almost the same wording, a strong statistical association may partly reflect duplicated content. The distinction between an emotional response to AI and uncertainty about future career conditions must therefore be evaluated before substantive conclusions are drawn. The multidimensional approaches of Wang and

Wang (2022) and Spurk et al. (2022) offer useful foundations, but their dimensions and items should not be combined into an unexamined total score.

The direction of the relationship is also uncertain. AI anxiety could accompany concern about career prospects, while employees whose careers already feel insecure may interpret AI more negatively. Contract type, tenure, sector, and access to training may influence both. A cross-sectional survey can estimate associations and investigate differences across groups, but it cannot establish whether anxiety precedes uncertainty. Recognising this limitation protects the study from claiming that AI has caused unemployment or psychological harm on the basis of self-reported perceptions alone.

The managerial evidence gap concerns the forms of support employees actually encounter and consider useful. A recommendation to provide training is incomplete if training occurs outside paid working time, does not match job tasks, or is inaccessible to temporary staff. Similarly, reassuring communication has limited meaning when employees receive no explanation of how their work will change. The proposed study will therefore examine reported access to learning opportunities, communication about AI-related change, and perceived organisational support. Its purpose is to inform proportionate HRM responses without assuming in advance that any particular intervention is effective.

RESEARCH OBJECTIVES AND QUESTIONS

The general objective is to examine the association between AI anxiety and career uncertainty among young professionals in Bangladesh and to identify evidence-informed implications for human resource management.

The specific objectives are:

1. To describe AI anxiety and career uncertainty, including their relevant dimensions, among the participating young professionals.
2. To assess the association between AI anxiety and career uncertainty while accounting for selected demographic and employment characteristics.
3. To examine how AI use, reported workplace AI adoption, and access to AI-related training are associated with these perceptions.
4. To investigate the associations of perceived organisational support and communication about technological change with career uncertainty, and explore whether organisational support changes the strength of its association with AI anxiety.
5. To identify respondents' preferred forms of career and learning support and develop practical implications for HRM within the limits of the study.

The corresponding research questions are:

1. What levels and dimensions of AI anxiety and career uncertainty are reported by the participating young professionals?
2. How is AI anxiety associated with career uncertainty after selected demographic and employment characteristics are considered?
3. How do AI use, reported workplace adoption, and access to AI-related training relate to AI anxiety and career uncertainty?

4. How are perceived organisational support and communication about technological change associated with career uncertainty, and does organisational support moderate the AI-anxiety–career-uncertainty association?
5. Which forms of organisational support do respondents consider useful for managing AI-related career concerns, and what implications follow for HRM?

The primary expectation is a positive association between AI anxiety and career uncertainty. The proposed resource perspective also suggests that stronger organisational support may accompany lower uncertainty. These expectations will guide analysis rather than determine its conclusions. The moderation question is exploratory and will be retained only if the sample size and measurement quality support it. Chapter 2 will develop the conceptual model and any formal hypotheses before data collection, distinguishing theoretically specified tests from subsequent exploratory analyses.

JUSTIFICATION AND SIGNIFICANCE

The academic contribution is to connect technology-related anxiety with a career perspective extending beyond the security of a current position. Existing constructs make this distinction possible, but their relationship requires contextual investigation. Using an employed population allows the study to consider actual organisational conditions, including training and communication, alongside individual concerns. This complements the student-focused Bangladesh evidence rather than treating students' expectations as a substitute for employees' experiences. It also makes the transition from general technological exposure to subjective career appraisal explicit.

The Bangladesh focus is significant because employment constraints may shape the meaning of a technological threat. Where alternative professional opportunities are difficult to obtain, uncertainty about future skill requirements may carry implications different from those in a labour market with easier mobility. Kapoor (2026) provides evidence of broader employment challenges, but the proposed study must investigate rather than presume how these conditions enter individual perceptions. It can also examine differences within the sample without presenting one occupational group, city, or educational background as representative of all young workers.

For human resource practitioners, the study can identify concerns that warrant different responses. Learning-related anxiety may suggest a need for accessible instruction and supported practice. Concern about career progression may require clearer skill frameworks and internal mobility pathways. Employees who do not understand how AI-related decisions are made may need opportunities to question those decisions. These are potential managerial responses to be considered against the findings, not established effects of an intervention. Tambe et al. (2019) emphasise employee contribution and accountability in AI-enabled management, supporting an

approach in which employees participate in implementation rather than receive only managerial announcements.

The study may also inform retention and career development. Brougham and Haar (2018) link replacement perceptions with employee attitudes and turnover intentions, making it reasonable for HRM to investigate such perceptions before reducing the issue to individual willingness to learn. At the same time, Brynjolfsson et al. (2025) demonstrate that AI assistance can improve work performance in a particular setting. Effective management therefore requires attention to both learning opportunities and the distribution of benefits. A useful outcome would be a clearer account of which employees feel supported and which report uncertainty despite access to technology.

Employee well-being is another concern. Career uncertainty can be experienced before any adverse employment event occurs. The present study will treat such experiences as legitimate subjects of organisational inquiry without diagnosing mental illness or identifying individual employees for managerial action. Aggregated findings may support confidential career discussions, fair access to development, and more specific communication about changing tasks. Recommendations should also distinguish what an employer can influence from structural employment conditions that require wider policy responses.

Methodologically, the study can contribute a transparent approach to adapting measures for a Bangladeshi professional sample. Cognitive testing, translation checks, assessment of dimensionality, and attention to overlapping items can improve the interpretability of results. The study will make no claim to provide a definitive national prevalence estimate or a fully validated Bangla instrument unless the design and evidence justify those claims. Its value lies in producing a bounded, reproducible account that can support subsequent longitudinal research and evaluation of human resource practices.

OVERVIEW OF METHODOLOGY

A quantitative, cross-sectional survey is proposed. The design is suitable for describing perceptions and estimating associations across a defined sample at one point in time. The study will use a structured questionnaire with a short optional open-ended question on preferred organisational support. This additional question will contextualise the quantitative results; it will not be represented as a separate qualitative study or a full mixed-methods design. All procedures remain proposed and subject to supervisory and institutional requirements.

For this study, young professionals will be operationally defined as adults aged 22–35 who are currently employed in a professional, technical, administrative, or managerial role in Bangladesh and have at least six months of paid work experience. This is a study-specific early-career boundary, not an official national definition of youth. Students without qualifying employment and people who are currently unemployed will be excluded from the main survey. The eligibility rules will distinguish employees from interns and independent freelancers so that the organisational-support questions have a consistent referent. Results will apply to the eligible sample rather than the wider population of young people.

Recruitment is proposed across selected organisations and professional networks in sectors such as information technology, banking and financial services, telecommunications, and business services. These sectors identify a feasible recruitment scope, not a claim of verified sector-wide AI adoption. Employer size, location, sector, contract type, and length of service will be recorded. Where a complete employee sampling frame is unavailable, purposive recruitment with sector and gender monitoring will be used and disclosed as non-probability sampling. Recruitment through multiple channels can improve diversity, but cannot remove self-selection or generate national representativeness.

The main predictors and outcomes will draw on published measures. AI-anxiety items will be considered from Wang and Wang (2022), while selected career-insecurity dimensions from Spurk et al. (2022) will inform the operational definition of career uncertainty. The study will examine the relevance of each dimension before specifying its scoring model. Job-replacement anxiety will remain identifiable rather than being silently removed or conflated with career uncertainty. Analyses of anxiety dimensions excluding replacement-related items can be used as a pre-specified sensitivity check. Any shortening or adaptation will be documented and will not be described as use of an unchanged validated scale.

Perceived organisational support will draw on the construct developed by Eisenberger et al. (1986). Separate factual and perception questions will address training access, recent AI use, and communication about technological change. Self-reported AI use will not serve as an objective exposure index, and frequency of use will not be equated with competence. Questionnaire development will include expert review, cognitive interviews with eligible professionals, and a pilot. English and Bangla versions, where used, will undergo translation and back-translation with reconciliation. Required permissions will be checked before reproducing copyrighted items.

The final sample target will be determined through an a priori power analysis for the primary regression model, using the smallest substantively meaningful association, the number of planned predictors, the significance criterion, and desired power. Recruitment planning will allow for ineligible and incomplete responses. An interaction test generally needs additional power, so the moderation analysis will not be promised merely because a conventional sample-size rule is met. The assumptions and final target will be specified in Chapter 3 before recruitment.

Analysis will begin with eligibility checks, missing-data assessment, and descriptive summaries. Internal consistency and factor structure will be examined as feasible, with particular attention to discrimination between anxiety and career uncertainty. Correlations and multivariable regression will assess the primary association, reporting effect estimates and confidence intervals alongside significance tests. Selected covariates will be justified in advance. If feasible, an interaction between AI anxiety and organisational support will address the exploratory moderation question.

Alternative scoring and sample-composition checks will assess sensitivity. Findings will remain associational because reverse direction, shared reporting, and unmeasured confounding cannot be excluded.

Before recruitment, the researcher will obtain the institution's required ethics review or other determination and any necessary organisational access permissions. Participation will be voluntary, with informed consent, an option to skip questions, and clear limits on withdrawing data after anonymous submission. Employers will not receive identifiable responses. Names and employee identifiers will not be collected in the analysis dataset; small subgroup reporting will be controlled to reduce re-identification. Data will be stored securely for the institutionally required period. The principal limitations are non-probability recruitment, self-reporting, possible common-method bias, and the inability of a single survey to establish change over time or causal effects.

THESIS STRUCTURE OUTLINE

The thesis will contain six chapters, following the Executive Master of Business Administration (EMBA) thesis structure.

Chapter 1 introduces the topic and Bangladesh context, establishes the research problem, states the objectives and questions, explains the significance, and outlines the proposed methodology.

Chapter 2 reviews the literature. It will develop the theoretical framework, distinguish AI anxiety from job and career insecurity, compare international and Bangladesh studies, evaluate measurement approaches, and specify the conceptual model and research gaps. The literature used in Chapter 1 establishes the study's rationale; Chapter 2 will provide the fuller critical synthesis.

Chapter 3 sets out the methodology in detail, including the research design, eligibility criteria, recruitment and sampling strategy, sample-size justification, instruments, translation and pilot procedures, analysis plan, ethical arrangements, and limitations.

Chapter 4 presents the collected data and findings. It will report the sample characteristics, measurement and reliability assessments, descriptive patterns, and results addressing each research question. No findings are assumed at this proposal stage.

Chapter 5 discusses the findings in relation to the literature and theoretical framework. It will examine alternative explanations, evaluate the study's limitations, and consider implications for organisational communication, development, and other HRM practices.

Chapter 6 summarises the findings and contributions, presents evidence-based recommendations, and identifies future research priorities. References and appendices follow, including instruments and consent materials with participant confidentiality protected.

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